

FREE DOWNLOAD

The Senior Style Guide *for Guys.*

Senior Portraits Done Right.

What to wear.

How to groom.

How to pose — and not look stiff.

What to expect, start to finish.

27

WELCOME

You Deserve Portraits That Actually Look Like You.

"Season after season. Family after family. We know what works on camera."

After years of senior sessions, we've learned one thing: the best portraits aren't built on luck — they're built on preparation.

This guide is everything we know, written specifically for the guys. Because most senior portrait guides are written for girls — and you deserve the same level of preparation.

Read it once before your session. Share it with your parents. Then show up and let us do what we do.

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01

What to Wear.

What you wear is one of the biggest factors in how your images feel. The right outfit doesn't just look great — it makes you look confident, capable, and completely yourself.

THE FOUNDATION

- + **Fitted beats baggy — every time.**
Well-fitted clothes photograph clean and polished. Loose, baggy fits look sloppy on camera. You don't need to go tight — just go fitted.
- + **Stick to solid colors and simple patterns.**
Solid neutrals, subtle textures, and simple patterns keep the focus on your face. Large logos, bold graphics, and busy prints compete with you.
- + **Fabric texture adds depth.**
Linen, denim, chino, knit, and flannel all create visual richness on camera. A plain white tee in a great fabric reads better than a busy patterned shirt.

WEAR THIS

- + Fitted chinos, dark denim, dress pants
- + Solid colors and subtle textures
- + Layers — jacket, flannel, open button-down
- + Shoes that match the overall vibe
- + Outfits pressed and ready the night before
- + Something you genuinely feel good in

BUILD YOUR OUTFITS

- + **One dressed-up look.**
Button-down (tucked or untucked), chinos or dark denim, clean shoes. Not a suit — unless that's genuinely you. Think polished, not costumed.
- + **One casual, real look.**
Jeans and a fitted tee, your favorite jacket, something you actually wear. This is often where the best images happen.
- + **Something that means something.**
Your sport. Your instrument. Your culture. Your letter jacket. Props and meaningful items create images that will still make sense to you in 20 years.

AVOID THIS

- Baggy or oversized fits
- Large logos, bold graphics, busy patterns
- Brand new shoes not yet broken in
- Neon or overly bright colors
- Clothes that need constant adjusting
- Anything you've never worn before

02

Hair & Grooming.

Camera lenses are honest. They catch everything — the razor redness, the shine, the haircut that isn't quite right. A little extra prep the day before changes everything on camera.

HAIR

- + **Haircut: 3–5 days before. Not the morning of.**
A fresh cut that's had a few days to settle looks natural and polished. A same-day cut can look too sharp or uneven on camera. Plan it the week of your session.
- + **Style the day before if possible.**
Day-old hair holds better and sits more naturally than freshly washed. Whatever your length, let it settle overnight when you can.
- + **If you have long hair — embrace it, work it.**
Use a light-hold product on the pieces framing your face and your hairline. Those sections catch light and movement most on camera. Avoid heavy product that makes it look stiff or greasy — natural flow photographs best.
- + **Keep product light — and watch the flyaways.**
Too much gel or pomade reads as greasy or stiff on camera. Aim for flexible hold and shine-free finishes. Then spend a few extra minutes on the pieces around your hairline — flyaways and frizz show up in every single frame.

FACE & SKIN

- + **Shave or trim the night before.**
Clean-shaven: shave the evening before to avoid razor redness and irritation. Beard: shape and trim 1–2 days ahead so it looks intentional, not rushed.
- + **Moisturize — starting now.**
Skin condition shows clearly in photos. Moisturize daily starting a few days before. Well-hydrated skin photographs with natural texture, not rough or flaky.
- + **Mattifying powder is your friend.**
Translucent setting powder reduces shine without looking 'made up.' It's highly recommended — Texas heat and studio lights both create shine fast. Pick some up at any drugstore.
- + **SPF flashback is real.**
Physical sunscreens (zinc, titanium dioxide) create a white cast in flash photography. On session day, switch to SPF-free or chemical SPF formulas if you use sunscreen.

THE SHORT VERSION

Haircut 5 days before. Shave the night before. Moisturize daily. Pick up mattifying powder. Avoid new products session-day. Show up looking like the best version of yourself.

03

How to Pose.

Posing is a skill. It's learned and practiced — and most people have never been taught. The stiffness you feel in photos? Completely normal. Not a you problem. A practice problem. Here's what to know.

THE BASICS THAT CHANGE EVERYTHING

+ The chin trick. Practice this.

Push your chin slightly forward and down. This defines your jawline, eliminates double-chin shadows, and makes you look more assertive on camera. Practice in a mirror — it will change your photos. Every time.

+ Shift your weight.

Standing straight-on with equal weight looks flat and rigid. Shift slightly to one leg, let a hip drop naturally. Suddenly you have shape, angle, and personality. This one move changes almost everything.

+ Turn slightly — don't face straight on.

Facing the camera head-on is rarely anyone's best angle. Turn your shoulders 20–30 degrees. We'll find your best side in the first few minutes. Most guys have a stronger side they don't know about yet.

+ Give your hands a job.

Flat hands hanging at your sides look awkward on camera. Hook a thumb in a pocket. Hold something meaningful — your helmet, your instrument. Arms crossed, hands in jacket pockets, one hand at your side and one touching your jaw. Give them a reason to be where they are.

+ Lean slightly forward — when it fits the pose.

In seated or casual poses, a subtle forward lean creates confident posture and a stronger presence on camera. Leaning back reads as passive. This doesn't apply to every standing pose — we'll tell you when it works.

+ Move. Don't just hold a pose.

The best images almost always happen between the planned poses — when you're adjusting, laughing, looking away and coming back. Poses are starting points, not destinations. Let yourself actually move.

+ Breathe.

Right before the shutter, take a breath and let half out. Your shoulders drop. Your expression softens. You go from 'trying to pose' to 'actually being there.' We'll cue this — just remember it's an option.

Trust us for the first 10 minutes. Almost every senior says the same thing afterward: "Once I relaxed, it just happened." That relaxation always comes. We'll get you there.

04

How to Prepare.

A little intentional preparation makes a bigger difference than most people expect. Here's exactly what to do — organized by when to do it.

ONE WEEK BEFORE

- + Finalize all outfits — try everything on
- + Schedule your haircut (3–5 days before session)
- + Pick up mattifying powder and any makeup products
- + Confirm your session time, location, and parking
- + Think about meaningful props or items to bring
- + Start hydrating more than usual

THREE DAYS BEFORE

- + Steam or iron all outfits and hang them
- + Start moisturizing your face daily
- + Avoid salty foods that cause puffiness
- + Get on a reasonable sleep schedule
- + Do a dry run of your outfits one more time
- + Trim or shape your beard if you're keeping it

THE DAY BEFORE

- + Pack your bag: outfits, shoes, accessories
- + Shave or trim beard (clean-shaven) or shape (beard)
- + Style hair if letting it settle overnight
- + Confirm session details one final time
- + Lay out everything — make zero morning decisions
- + Do something relaxing. Rest well.

MORNING OF

- + Eat a real meal — not a granola bar
- + Apply any product in natural light if possible
- + Give yourself extra time to get ready
- + Arrive 10 minutes early
- + Leave the stress in the car
- + Bring water and a small snack

05

What to Expect.

Knowing how the process works removes the guesswork entirely. Here's the full picture — from your first message through your final gallery.

WHEN YOU REACH OUT

Reach out through the contact form at nydamphoto.com or reply to any email we've sent. We respond the same day on weekdays. We'll schedule a quick call to understand what you're looking for, answer every question, and make sure we're the right fit. No pressure — just a real conversation.

BEFORE YOUR SESSION

Once booked, you'll receive a confirmation with your session time, location, and parking details. We'll also send any session-specific notes. Reach out any time before your session with questions — there are no silly ones. Please arrive 5–10 minutes early so we can settle in and start without rushing.

DURING YOUR SESSION

We ease into things — no jumping straight into formal poses. The first 10–15 minutes are always a warmup: getting comfortable, finding the light, laughing at something. By the time we get to the directed work, you'll feel completely natural. We direct everything: where to stand, how to angle your body, where to look, what to do with your hands. You will never be left guessing. Outfit changes are built into longer sessions — we plan the flow around them.

AFTER YOUR SESSION

You'll receive a link to your private, password-protected online gallery of fully edited, high-resolution, print-ready images. We edit for color, light, skin tone, and overall mood — every image is consistent, polished, and ready to print, frame, and share. From your gallery you can download, share, and order professional prints directly.

About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceañeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding
Every specialty. One standard of care.

KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us.

The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift.

A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

With warmth,

Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography

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